

Narrative Crossroads: Historical Framework Template

A character analysis framework for exploring historical figures at pivotal moments

Overview

This template adapts the Narrative Crossroads framework for analyzing historical events and figures. Teachers can customize this template for specific historical periods, events, or movements to help students explore key decisions and motivations that shaped history.

Setting Context

- **Time Period:** [Specify the historical period]
- **Location:** [Specify the geographic location(s)]
- **Social Context:** [Describe relevant social, political, and economic conditions]
- **Atmosphere:** [Describe the emotional tone of the period]

Character Options

Choose, or roll a die.

Roll	Character	What they want	What they fear
1–2	[Historical Figure 1]	[What the record shows they wanted]	[What the record shows they feared]
3–4	[Historical Figure 2]		
5–6	[Historical Figure 3]		

Threshold Moments

Choose, or roll a die. Everyone works the same moment.

Roll	Threshold Moment	Why it is a threshold
1–2	[Historical Moment 1]	[Decision]; and [Decision]
3–4	[Historical Moment 2]	[Decision]; and [Decision]
5–6	[Historical Moment 3]	[Decision]; and [Decision]

The Three Lenses

Everyone works from the same character at the same threshold moment. Each student takes one lens — pick, or roll a die so the room spreads across all three. The die only chooses the way in; nothing is rolled against a character, and there is nothing to succeed or fail at.

Roll	Lens	What it asks at this moment
1–2	Confrontation	A clash. What are you up against, and what does facing it cost?
3–4	Comprehension	A realization. What do you understand now that you didn't a moment ago?
5–6	Connection	The bonds. Who is this really about, and what do you owe them?

Then write a few sentences in the character's voice, at that moment, showing one thing from the character's wants or fears. The writing is the play.

Example Adaptation: Civil Rights Movement (1960s)

Character Options

Roll	Character	What they want	What they fear
1–2	Civil Rights Activist	The law changed, and changed to last	That the movement is blamed for the violence done to it
3–4	Student Protester	To act now, not to wait to be ready	Letting the others down
5–6	Local Community Leader	To keep the neighbourhood whole	Losing the standing that lets them help at all

Threshold Moments

Roll	Threshold Moment	Why it is a threshold
1–2	Before a sit-in protest	Whether to participate despite the risk, and who has to be told
3–4	During police confrontation	Holding to non-violence while the group looks to you
5–6	Meeting with local officials	What to demand, and what an alliance here would cost

Implementation Guide

Classroom Setup (45–60 minutes)

1. **Introduction (5 min):** Explain the round and distribute cards
2. **Character Selection (5 min):** Students choose a character, or roll a die for one
3. **Threshold Moment (5 min):** The teacher frames one moment for the whole room

4. **Evidence (10 min):** Students fill the Character Frame — what this character wants and fears, with a line or page number
5. **Take a lens and write (15–20 min):** Students take a lens and write in character
6. **Harvest (10–15 min):** Read several aloud, at least one per lens, then ask which reading the text supports

Materials Needed

- A die per table, if you want to assign lenses by chance rather than choice. It is optional; students can simply pick.
 - Character Frame cards
 - Copy of the text
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Assessment Options

- **First-Person Narrative:** Students write from the historical figure's perspective
 - **Decision Analysis:** Students examine how the figure's decision shaped subsequent events
 - **Comparative Analysis:** Students compare different approaches to similar historical challenges
 - **Creative Historical Fiction:** Students develop plausible alternative historical outcomes
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History Standards Alignment

Codes below are from the C3 Framework for Social Studies State Standards.

- **D2.His.4.9-12** — Analyze complex and interacting factors that influenced the perspectives of people during different historical eras
 - **D2.His.14.9-12** — Analyze multiple and complex causes and effects of events in the past
 - **D2.His.16.9-12** — Integrate evidence from multiple relevant historical sources and interpretations into a reasoned argument about the past
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Adaptation Tips

1. Research Historical Figures

- Identify 3 key figures involved in the historical event
- Research their backgrounds, motivations, and key decisions
- Record what the figure wanted and feared, with a source for each

2. Identify Threshold Moments

- Look for decisions that could have gone multiple ways
- Focus on moments where individuals had agency
- Consider both well-known and lesser-known historical turning points

3. Customize Questions

- Adapt questions to reflect period-specific concerns
- Include questions that address the historical context
- Ensure questions explore counterfactual possibilities

4. Connect to Historical Evidence

- Ground the activity in primary sources where possible
- Provide historical context materials to students
- Encourage citation of historical evidence in reflections

Version 3

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